

COFFEE BARS

Bean THERE

The good old chai has been pushed aside by coffee culture that leaves behind its origins in staid, smoke-filled cafes serving filter brew and moves into pleasantly-lit spaces of unobtrusive music, exotic flavours and ceaseless chatter

**THE CUP THAT
CHEERS:** India
Coffee House in
Bangalore, 2005



■ By Swagata Sen

Coffee has always been more than just a drink. It has long been the excuse for that first date—a hesitant, much-deliberated-over question for the Indian teenager. It was also the fuel for intellectuals in the 1970s, who brought out anti-bourgeois literature, raised storms over injustices committed and vowed to change the world. All over a cup of coffee.

Now, drinking coffee is a lifestyle statement. It is a wifi-connected chillout zone where you pay 10

times what the cup actually costs because in a whole new culture of disposable incomes and shrinking spaces, social life is like Prufrock's, measured in coffee spoons. India has primarily been a tea-drinking nation, the popularity of coffee restricted to areas that grew the beans. Even three years ago, India was ranked 36th out of 53 coffee-drinking nations, according to an AC Nielsen survey. The lack of a coffee culture is thanks to our colonial lineage and mornings are usually imbued